

The Last Leaf

O. Henry · 1907

First published: The Trimmed Lamp, 1907

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Indiana 2023 edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Trimmed_Lamp_(1907)/The_Last_Leaf (revision 13324710), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (accessible text, well suited to the scaffolded-support track; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Last Leaf suggest about hope and the will to live?
- What does The Last Leaf suggest about art and sacrifice?
- What does The Last Leaf suggest about friendship?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Indiana 2023

9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1

Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Last Leaf	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*hope and the will to live* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Last Leaf

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about O. Henry's life or times connects to hope and the will to live in “The Last Leaf”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (hope and the will to live, art and sacrifice, friendship).

Standards: Indiana 2023 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2

Author biography

O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910.

Historical and cultural context

Greenwich Village around 1900 was a cheap neighbourhood of artists; pneumonia was a leading cause of death before antibiotics (penicillin was not used until the 1940s).

Publication and reception, then and now

Collected in The Trimmed Lamp (1907); it may have appeared first in a newspaper.

Then: A popular sentimental tale.

Now: Widely taught for its personification, theme of hope, and twist.

Overview (spoiler-free)

In a Greenwich Village studio, young artist Johnsy falls ill with pneumonia and decides she will die when the last ivy leaf falls from the vine outside.

Main themes

- hope and the will to live.
- sacrifice.
- art and its purpose.

Why it matters

It asks what art is for and how much hope matters in illness.

Spoilers · teacher only

One leaf never falls, and Johnsy recovers; old Behrman, a failed painter, had painted it on the wall during a storm, caught pneumonia and died. It was his masterpiece.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Last Leaf: Can a belief or hope change a physical outcome?
Prompt: Before we open The Last Leaf: Can a belief or hope change a physical outcome?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
personification; symbol; twist ending; dialect.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910. The world of the book. Greenwich Village around 1900 was a cheap neighbourhood of artists; pneumonia was a leading cause of death before antibiotics (penicillin was not used until the 1940s). Publication and reception. Collected in The Trimmed Lamp (1907); it may have appeared first in a newspaper. Then: A popular sentimental tale. Now: Widely taught for its personification, theme of hope, and twist.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "When the last one falls I must go, too" slowly and put it in my own words: Johnsy says when the last leaf falls she must go too. Next, craft. I notice the simple, quiet words, which sound resigned. The strongest word is "last": it ties her life to the final leaf. Then, effect. What does Johnsy's statement show about her? My answer: She has given up hope; O. Henry makes us wonder if hope can save her.

> *When the last one falls I must go, too (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "When the last one falls I must go, too" slowly and put it in my own words: Johnsy says when the last leaf falls she must go too. Next, craft. I notice the simple, quiet words, which sound resigned. The strongest word is "last": it ties her life to the final leaf. Then, effect. What does Johnsy's statement show about her? My answer: She has given up hope; O. Henry makes us wonder if hope can save her.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): In a Greenwich Village studio, young artist Johnsy falls ill with pneumonia and decides she will die when the last ivy leaf falls from the vine outside. Themes to track: hope and the will to live.: sacrifice.: art and its purpose.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Example page. Theme: hope and the will to live. Prediction: I expect this idea to be tested when a character has to choose between what they want and what others expect. Question: what will The Last Leaf suggest about hope and the will to live by the end?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Last Leaf: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Example page. Theme: hope and the will to live. Prediction: I expect this idea to be tested when a character has to choose between what they want and what others expect. Question: what will The Last Leaf suggest about hope and the will to live by the end?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Last Leaf still matter? It asks what art is for and how much hope matters in illness.
Anchor question: Why might The Last Leaf still be taught today?
Facilitation: It asks what art is for and how much hope matters in illness.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
O. Henry set many stories in Greenwich Village, where poor artists lived. Why might he be drawn to such characters? Answer: Accept answers such as: he knew struggling city people; he admired their kindness and sacrifice; artists gave him a way to show hope and art.
Exit ticket: O. Henry set many stories in Greenwich Village, where poor artists lived. Why might he be drawn to such characters?
Answer: Accept answers such as: he knew struggling city people; he admired their kindness and sacrifice; artists gave him a way to show hope and art.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Last Leaf.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "O. Henry" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/O-Henry); NCpedia, "Porter, William Sydney (O. Henry)" (https://www.ncpedia.org/biography/porter-william-sydney); O. Henry Museum (Austin) (https://www.austintexas.gov/department/o-henry-museum)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- First-periodical publication details are uncertain; cite the 1907 collection.

Lesson 2: The Last Leaf

Focus: hope created by an act of sacrifice

Objective: Students will analyze how symbolism develops in "The Last Leaf" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Indiana 2023 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (illness and death, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Illness and death. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…she can sell the editor man with it, and buy port wine for her sick child, and pork chops for…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes illness and death.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

In Greenwich Village, young artist Johnsy is dying of pneumonia and believes she will die when the last ivy leaf falls outside her window. Her friend Sue tells their neighbor, the old failed painter Behrman. Through a stormy night one leaf survives, and Johnsy regains her will to live. Then they learn Behrman died of pneumonia after painting the leaf on the wall in the storm: his masterpiece.

Background: Published in 1907. Pneumonia was a leading cause of death in crowded New York tenements before antibiotics.

Significance: It links art, hope and sacrifice through a single symbol.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to sacrifice because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes illness and death.
Prompt: Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to sacrifice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: swaggered — walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way; zephyrs — soft, gentle breezes; serrated — having a jagged, saw-toothed edge; merciless — having or showing no mercy; congenial — pleasant and well suited. "merciless": Origin: an English formation from mercy + -less.
Words: swaggered: walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way · zephyrs: soft, gentle breezes · serrated: having a jagged, saw-toothed edge · merciless: having or showing no mercy · congenial: pleasant and well suited

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1907. Pneumonia was a leading cause of death in crowded New York tenements before antibiotics. It links art, hope and sacrifice through a single symbol. Personification: Pneumonia is "Mr. Pneumonia," a cold stranger with an icy finger. Symbolism: The leaf stands for life and hope. Dialect: Behrman's German accent marks him as gruff but loving. Watch for the last leaf: endurance and hope.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "When the last one falls I must go, too" slowly and put it in my own words: Johnsy, sick with pneumonia, tells Sue she will die when the last leaf falls. Next, craft. I notice she ties her life to the leaf, which shows she has given up. The strongest word is "falls": it shows a quiet, inevitable motion. Then, effect. Why does Johnsy believe she will die when the last leaf falls? My answer: She has lost the will to live; the story will show how hope, and Behrman's sacrifice, change that.

> *When the last one falls I must go, too* *(The Last Leaf, paragraph 21)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "When the last one falls I must go, too" slowly and put it in my own words: Johnsy, sick with pneumonia, tells Sue she will die when the last leaf falls. Next, craft. I notice she ties her life to the leaf, which shows she has given up. The strongest word is "falls": it shows a quiet, inevitable motion. Then, effect. Why does Johnsy believe she will die when the last leaf falls? My answer: She has lost the will to live; the story will show how hope, and Behrman's sacrifice, change that.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The verb "stalked" turns illness into a predator moving through the colony. Ask: How does this line connect to sacrifice? Expected: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. (Personification.)

> *whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony* *(The Last Leaf, paragraph 4)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The verb "stalked" turns illness into a predator moving through the colony.
Ask: How does this line connect to sacrifice?
Expected answer: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. (Personification.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for personification, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about hope created by an act of sacrifice? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Last Leaf develops the idea of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. When the text says "it's Behrman's masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell" (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55), it shows this directly. Behrman, who never painted a masterpiece, paints one leaf, and Sue says "it's Behrman's masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"; its value is that it saved Johnsy.
Task: Annotate the story for personification, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about hope created by an act of sacrifice? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Last Leaf develops the idea of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. When the text says "it's Behrman's masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell" (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55), it shows this directly. Behrman, who never painted a masterpiece, paints one leaf, and Sue says "it's Behrman's masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"; its value is that it saved Johnsy.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think? Ask: was Behrman's sacrifice worth it?
Anchor question: Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think?
Facilitation: Ask: was Behrman's sacrifice worth it?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about hope created by an act of sacrifice? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. ("it's Behrman's masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell", The Last Leaf, paragraph 55). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about hope created by an act of sacrifice? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. ("it's Behrman's masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell", The Last Leaf, paragraph 55). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how personification shapes hope created by an act of sacrifice. Key takeaway: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Personification:** Pneumonia is "Mr. Pneumonia," a cold stranger with an icy finger.
- **Symbolism:** The leaf stands for life and hope.
- **Dialect:** Behrman's German accent marks him as gruff but loving.

Themes and how they develop

- **sacrifice:** Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's.

Symbols and motifs

- **the last leaf:** endurance and hope.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21) Her despair.
- “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55) The reveal.
- “whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 4) Personification.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people.
Evidence: “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55)
Reasoning: Behrman, who never painted a masterpiece, paints one leaf, and Sue says "it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"; its value is that it saved Johnsy.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
swaggered (verb)	walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way	*Then she swaggered into Johnsy’s room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime.*	

zephyrs (noun)	soft, gentle breezes	*A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer.*	
serrated (adjective)	having a jagged, saw-toothed edge	*Still dark green near its stem, but with its serrated edges tinted with the yellow of dissolution and decay, it hung bravely from a branch some twenty feet above the ground.*	
merciless (adjective)	having or showing no mercy	*When it was light enough Johnsy, the merciless, commanded that the shade be raised.*	"merciless": Origin: an English formation from mercy + -less. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/merciless#Etymology)
congenial (adjective)	pleasant and well suited	*They had met at the table d'hote of an Eighth street "Delmonico's," and found their tastes in art, chicory salad and bishop sleeves so congenial that the joint studio resulted.*	
valuable (adjective)	useful; worth having	*An artist once discovered a valuable possibility in this street.*	
clinical (adjective)	relating to the medical treatment of patients	*"She has one chance in—let us say, ten," he said;' as he shook down the mercury in his clinical thermometer.*	
ravager (noun)	one who destroys or lays waste	*Over on the east side this ravager strode boldly, smiting his victims by scores, but his feet trod slowly through the maze of the narrow and moss-grown "places."*	
solicitously (adverb)	with anxious care for someone	*Sue looked solicitously out the window.*	"solicitously": Origin of "solicitous": Latin sōlicitus. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/solicitous#Etymology)
chivalric (adjective)	relating to the gallant, protective code of knights	*Pneumonia was not what you would call a chivalric old gentleman.*	

Discussion questions

1. Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think?
2. Where does symbolism appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with hope and the will to live?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What illness does Johnsy have? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Pneumonia
2. What does Johnsy believe will happen when the last leaf falls? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: She will die
3. Who is Behrman? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece
4. Why does the last leaf never fall? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Behrman painted it on the wall
5. What happens to Behrman? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: He dies of pneumonia
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Last Leaf" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: In Greenwich Village, young artist Johnsy is dying of pneumonia and believes she will die when the last ivy leaf falls outside her window. Her friend Sue tells their neighbor, the old failed painter Behrman. Through a stormy night one leaf survives, and Johnsy regains her will to live. Then they learn Behrman died of pneumonia after painting the leaf on the wall in the storm: his masterpiece.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Last Leaf"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Last Leaf" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Then she swaggered into Johnsy's room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime." What does "swaggered" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: swaggered: walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way.
10. Reread: "A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer." What does "zephyrs" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.1, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: zephyrs: soft, gentle breezes.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Last Leaf" suggest about hope created by an act of sacrifice? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: It links art, hope and sacrifice through a single symbol.

2. Find one example of symbolism in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.13] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
3. How does the irony in this story shape what we understand about hope created by an act of sacrifice? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21): Her despair. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “IN a little district west of Washington Square the streets have run crazy and broken themselves into small strips called “places.””, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.13] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Last Leaf”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: In Greenwich Village, young artist Johnsy is dying of pneumonia and believes she will die when the last ivy leaf falls outside her window. Her friend Sue tells their neighbor, the old failed painter Behrman. Through a stormy night one leaf survives, and Johnsy regains her will to live. Then they…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Last Leaf” set up that the rest of The Last Leaf will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.3] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55): The reveal. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 4): Personification. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Can a person's attitude affect whether they get well? What do you think?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with hope and the will to live? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21): Her despair. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Background: Published in 1907. Pneumonia was a leading cause of death in crowded New York tenements before antibiotics. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.2, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55): The reveal. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “It links art, hope and sacrifice through a single symbol.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 4): Personification. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21): Her despair. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Last Leaf” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about hope created by an act of sacrifice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55): The reveal. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Last Leaf”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 4): Personification. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to art and sacrifice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21): Her despair. Theme link:

Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the symbolism in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.13] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55): The reveal. On symbolism: The leaf stands for life and hope. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Last Leaf” treats hope created by an act of sacrifice with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Last Leaf see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 4): Personification. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve hope and the will to live? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21): Her despair. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about hope created by an act of sacrifice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55): The reveal. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.CC.4, 11-12.RC.1] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Useful evidence: “whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 4): Personification. Theme link: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Symbolism:** look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Johnsy believe will happen when the last leaf falls?
   A. She will die
   B. Spring will come
   C. She will paint again
   D. Sue will leave

   Key: A (She will die)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "An artist once discovered a _____ possibility in this street." Word bank: swaggered, valuable, serrated, zephyrs

   Key: valuable
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What happens to Behrman?
   A. He moves away
   B. He dies of pneumonia
   C. He becomes famous
   D. He marries Sue

   Key: B (He dies of pneumonia)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Last Leaf, paragraph 55: "it's Behrman's _____—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"

   Key: masterpiece
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Last Leaf, paragraph 4: "whom the doctors called _____, stalked about the colony"

   Key: Pneumonia
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why does the last leaf never fall?
   A. It was glued
   B. It was plastic
   C. The wind stopped
   D. Behrman painted it on the wall

   Key: D (Behrman painted it on the wall)
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What illness does Johnsy have?
   A. Tuberculosis
   B. Smallpox
   C. Cholera
   D. Pneumonia

   Key: D (Pneumonia)
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Over on the east side this _____ strode boldly, smiting his victims by scores, but his feet trod slowly through the maze of the narrow and moss-grown "places."" Word bank: serrated, swaggered, ravager, zephyrs

   Key: ravager
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Behrman?
   A. Johnsy's doctor

B. Sue's father

C. An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece

D. The landlord

Key: C (An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “They had met at the table d’hote of an Eighth street “Delmonico’s,” and found their tastes in art, chicory salad and bishop sleeves so _____ that the joint studio resulted.” Word bank: serrated, swaggered, congenial, zephyrs

    Key: congenial

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The reveal.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Her despair.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Last Leaf”?

    A. A family and a house collapsing together

    B. Reason defeating a hidden crime

    C. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

    D. A story so convincing it becomes real

    Key: C (Hope created by an act of sacrifice)

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55).

    Sample answer: Behrman, who never painted a masterpiece, paints one leaf, and Sue says "it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"; its value is that it saved Johnsy.

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Last Leaf”? The leaf stands for life and hope.

    A. Symbolism

    B. Alliteration

    C. Diction / vocabulary

    D. Plot

    Key: A (Symbolism)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The reveal.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: ““She has one chance in—let us say, ten,” he said;’ as he shook down the mercury in his _____ thermometer.” Word bank: clinical, serrated, swaggered, zephyrs

    Key: clinical

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 4). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Personification.
19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Last Leaf”? Pneumonia is "Mr. Pneumonia," a cold stranger with an icy finger.
    A. Imagery
    B. Irony
    C. Personification
    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: C (Personification)
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Her despair.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Behrman, who never painted a masterpiece, paints one leaf, and Sue says "it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"; its value is that it saved Johnsy.
22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how sacrifice develops from an earlier story to “The Last Leaf”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's.
23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Then she swaggered into Johnsy’s room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime.”, what does “swaggered” most nearly mean?
    A. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way
    B. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
    C. having or showing no mercy
    D. soft, gentle breezes

    Key: A (walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way)
24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “When it was light enough Johnsy, the merciless, commanded that the shade be raised.”, what does “merciless” most nearly mean?
    A. soft, gentle breezes
    B. having or showing no mercy
    C. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
    D. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way

    Key: B (having or showing no mercy)
25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Still dark green near its stem, but with its serrated edges tinted with the yellow of dissolution and decay, it hung bravely from a branch some twenty feet above the ground.”, what does “serrated” most nearly mean?
    A. soft, gentle breezes
    B. having or showing no mercy
    C. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge
    D. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way

Key: C (having a jagged, saw-toothed edge)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer.”, what does “zephyrs” most nearly mean?
    A. soft, gentle breezes
    B. having or showing no mercy
    C. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way
    D. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge

    Key: A (soft, gentle breezes)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	2, 5, 10, 3, 6, 17, 7, 9, 8, 12, 13, 11, 14, 18, 19, 20	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 6, 2, 7, 17, 3, 4, 9, 12, 11, 13, 19, 18, 15, 16, 20	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	1, 8, 2, 10, 5, 6, 17, 11, 13, 12, 18, 14, 15, 19, 20, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	17, 2, 8, 5, 4, 1, 12, 13, 11, 18, 14, 19, 15, 21, 20, 22	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	10, 2, 23, 24, 25, 11, 13, 12, 14, 18, 19, 15, 22, 16, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	10, 9, 6, 5, 26, 12, 11, 13, 19, 14, 18, 15, 16, 21, 22, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	10, 26, 2, 1, 9, 12, 11, 13, 18, 14, 15, 19, 20, 16, 22, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	10, 8, 23, 9, 3, 13, 12, 11, 19, 18, 14, 15, 16, 22, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	10, 17, 7, 24, 6, 11, 12, 13, 15, 19, 18, 14, 16, 20, 21, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	1, 8, 3, 23, 2, 11, 12, 13, 15, 19, 14, 18, 22, 21, 16, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Last Leaf,” how does Henry show hope created by an act of sacrifice? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the symbolism you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In The Last Leaf, how does Henry develop the idea of hope created by an act of sacrifice? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the symbolism in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Last Leaf develops the idea of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of symbolism and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1): Analyze how the structure of The Last Leaf (where it begins, turns and ends) and its symbolism shape the reader's understanding of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1): Two readers disagree about what The Last Leaf suggests about hope created by an act of sacrifice. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's symbolism and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses symbolism in The Last Leaf to complicate the reader's understanding of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Situate The Last Leaf within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of hope created by an act of sacrifice responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Read The Last Leaf alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of hope created by an act of sacrifice follows or bends those conventions, using the symbolism as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Last Leaf and its treatment of hope created by an act of sacrifice. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's symbolism and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Last Leaf as evidence for a larger claim about hope created by an act of sacrifice in The Last Leaf. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Last Leaf as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of hope created by an act of sacrifice. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Last Leaf.

SAT-style questions

1. *Still dark green near its stem, but with its serrated edges tinted with the yellow of dissolution and decay, it hung bravely from a branch some twenty feet above the ground.*

As used in the text, what does the word "serrated" most nearly mean?

A. with anxious care for someone

B. one who destroys or lays waste

C. relating to the gallant, protective code of knights

D. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge

2. *IN a little district west of Washington Square the streets have run crazy and broken themselves into small strips called "places." These "places" make strange angles and curves. One street crosses itself a time or two. An artist once discovered a valuable possibility in this street. Suppose a collector with a bill for paints, paper and canvas should, in traversing this route, suddenly meet himself coming back, without a cent having been paid on account!*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Last Leaf"?

A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

B. Waking into a changed nation

C. A story told to protect a livelihood

D. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

SAT key: 1. D (having a jagged, saw-toothed edge); 2. D (Hope created by an act of sacrifice)

Unit test

The Last Leaf: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: ""She has one chance in—let us say, ten," he said;' as he shook down the mercury in his _____ thermometer." Word bank: clinical, serrated, swaggered, zephyrs

   Key: clinical

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Behrman?

   A. Johnsy's doctor

   B. Sue's father

   C. An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece

   D. The landlord

   Key: C (An old painter who has never painted his masterpiece)

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Last Leaf, paragraph 55: "it's Behrman's _____—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"

   Key: masterpiece

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Johnsy believe will happen when the last leaf falls?

   A. She will die

   B. Spring will come

   C. She will paint again

   D. Sue will leave

   Key: A (She will die)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What happens to Behrman?

   A. He moves away

   B. He dies of pneumonia

   C. He becomes famous

   D. He marries Sue

   Key: B (He dies of pneumonia)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why does the last leaf never fall?

   A. It was glued

   B. It was plastic

   C. The wind stopped

   D. Behrman painted it on the wall

   Key: D (Behrman painted it on the wall)

7. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Last Leaf, paragraph 4: "whom the doctors called _____, stalked about the colony"

   Key: Pneumonia

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "They had met at the table d'hote of an Eighth street "Delmonico's," and found their tastes in art, chicory salad and bishop sleeves so _____ that the joint studio resulted." Word bank: serrated, swaggered, congenial, zephyrs

   Key: congenial

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What illness does Johnsy have?

   A. Tuberculosis

   B. Smallpox

   C. Cholera

   D. Pneumonia

   Key: D (Pneumonia)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Over on the east side this _____ strode boldly, smiting his victims by scores, but his feet trod slowly through the maze of the narrow and moss-grown "places."" Word bank: serrated, swaggered, ravager, zephyrs

    Key: ravager

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "An artist once discovered a _____ possibility in this street." Word bank: swaggered, valuable, serrated, zephyrs

    Key: valuable

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "it's Behrman's masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell" (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The reveal.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Last Leaf"?

    A. A family and a house collapsing together

    B. Reason defeating a hidden crime

    C. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

    D. A story so convincing it becomes real

    Key: C (Hope created by an act of sacrifice)

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "When the last one falls I must go, too" (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Her despair.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “whom the doctors called Pneumonia, stalked about the colony” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 4). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Personification.
16. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Last Leaf”? Pneumonia is "Mr. Pneumonia," a cold stranger with an icy finger.
    A. Imagery
    B. Irony
    C. Personification
    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: C (Personification)
17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Last Leaf”? The leaf stands for life and hope.
    A. Symbolism
    B. Alliteration
    C. Diction / vocabulary
    D. Plot

    Key: A (Symbolism)
18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The reveal.
19. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 55).
    Sample answer: Behrman, who never painted a masterpiece, paints one leaf, and Sue says "it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"; its value is that it saved Johnsy.
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “When the last one falls I must go, too” (The Last Leaf, paragraph 21) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Her despair.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Behrman's leaf proves that true art serves people.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Behrman, who never painted a masterpiece, paints one leaf, and Sue says "it’s Behrman’s masterpiece—he painted it there the night that the last leaf fell"; its value is that it saved Johnsy.
22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how sacrifice develops from an earlier story to “The Last Leaf”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Behrman gives his life for Johnsy's.
23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Still dark green near its stem, but with its serrated edges tinted with the yellow of dissolution and decay, it hung bravely from a branch some twenty feet above the ground.”, what does “serrated” most nearly mean?
    A. soft, gentle breezes
    B. having or showing no mercy

C. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge

D. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way

Key: C (having a jagged, saw-toothed edge)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Then she swaggered into Johnsy's room with her drawing board, whistling ragtime.", what does "swaggered" most nearly mean?

A. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way

B. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge

C. having or showing no mercy

D. soft, gentle breezes

Key: A (walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "When it was light enough Johnsy, the merciless, commanded that the shade be raised.", what does "merciless" most nearly mean?

A. soft, gentle breezes

B. having or showing no mercy

C. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge

D. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way

Key: B (having or showing no mercy)

26. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "A mite of a little woman with blood thinned by California zephyrs was hardly fair game for the red-fisted, short-breathed old duffer.", what does "zephyrs" most nearly mean?

A. soft, gentle breezes

B. having or showing no mercy

C. walked or behaved in a boastful, arrogant way

D. having a jagged, saw-toothed edge

Key: A (soft, gentle breezes)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	7, 3, 4, 8, 5, 6, 10, 11, 1, 9, 2, 12, 13, 14, 15, 17, 19, 20	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	7, 5, 8, 2, 11, 1, 10, 9, 4, 3, 13, 14, 12, 15, 19, 16, 20, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	5, 11, 6, 1, 10, 4, 8, 9, 3, 12, 13, 14, 17, 16, 15, 19, 21, 20	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	11, 10, 1, 6, 5, 7, 4, 9, 14, 13, 12, 17, 15, 19, 16, 22, 20, 18	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	11, 1, 7, 23, 24, 8, 9, 14, 13, 12, 17, 16, 19, 15, 20, 18, 21, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	9, 23, 24, 8, 25, 3, 10, 14, 13, 12, 19, 16, 15, 17, 22, 21, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	9, 26, 11, 3, 1, 24, 8, 14, 12, 13, 16, 15, 17, 19, 20, 21, 18, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	8, 5, 26, 24, 6, 4, 10, 14, 13, 12, 19, 16, 17, 15, 21, 22, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	25, 7, 10, 26, 24, 6, 23, 14, 13, 12, 19, 15, 17, 16, 21, 18, 22, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	10, 6, 2, 26, 7, 1, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 19, 17, 16, 21, 20, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Last Leaf: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how O. Henry develops hope and the will to live across The Last Leaf. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Last Leaf and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to art and sacrifice.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Last Leaf. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Last Leaf finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of friendship. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Hope and the will to live

Scaffolded support (600 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Last Leaf teaches about hope and the will to live. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops hope and the will to live across The Last Leaf. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Last Leaf (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of hope and the will to live. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Last Leaf (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of hope and the will to live, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Last Leaf's treatment of hope and the will to live in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on hope and the will to live in The Last Leaf, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Art and sacrifice

Scaffolded support (600 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Last Leaf teaches about art and sacrifice. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops art and sacrifice across The Last Leaf. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Last Leaf (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of art and sacrifice. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Last Leaf (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of art and sacrifice, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Last Leaf's treatment of art and sacrifice in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on art and sacrifice in The Last Leaf, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Friendship

Scaffolded support (600 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Last Leaf teaches about friendship. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops friendship in The Last Leaf. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops friendship across The Last Leaf. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Last Leaf (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of friendship. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of friendship in The Last Leaf. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Last Leaf (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of friendship, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Last Leaf's treatment of friendship in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on friendship in The Last Leaf that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Indiana 2023: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on friendship in The Last Leaf. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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